Official Travel Guide: Highlights of Jeju Island

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Coverage: Natural Heritage, Coastal Parks, and UNESCO Sites

1. UNESCO World Natural Heritage: Hallasan Mountain

Mount Hallasan is the central shield volcano of Jeju Island, rising to an elevation of 1,947 meters above sea level. In 2007, UNESCO designated Jeju Volcanic Island and Lava Tubes as South Koreas first World Natural Heritage site. Hikers aiming to reach the Baeknokdam crater lake summit must select between two official courses: the Seongpanak Trail (9.6 km, approximately 4.5 to 5 hours one-way) and the Gwaneumsa Trail (8.7 km, approximately 5 hours one-way). Both summit trails mandate prior online reservations through the official national park reservation portal to preserve sensitive sub-alpine flora and protect Korean fir forests.

Hikers must be aware that strict seasonal entry cutoff checkpoints are enforced at Jindallaebat Shelter on the Seongpanak route (12:00 PM during winter) and Samgakbong Shelter on the Gwaneumsa route to ensure safe descent before nightfall.

2. Eastern Geological Treasures: Seongsan Ilchulbong & Manjanggul Cave

Seongsan Ilchulbong, commonly known as Sunrise Peak, is a dramatic 182-meter-high hydrovolcanic tuff cone situated on the eastern tip of Jeju Island. Formed by undersea volcanic explosions roughly 5,000 years ago, it possesses a massive bowl-like crater 600 meters wide. Operating hours during the summer season are 07:00 to 20:00 (ticketing closes at 19:00), and admission for adults is 5,000 KRW. The trail ascends via wooden steps in 20 to 30 minutes. At the base of the cliffs, visitor performances by Jeju female divers (Haenyeo) take place daily at 13:30 and 15:00.

Located further northwest, Manjanggul Lava Tube features a 1.0 km section open to the public, showcasing the worlds largest known lava column measuring 7.6 meters high. The subterranean cave maintains a steady internal temperature between 11°C and 15°C throughout the entire year, requiring visitors to bring warm outerwear even in midsummer.

3. Transportation and the Jeju Olle Trail System

Jeju Island operates a well-organized island-wide bus network categorized into Red Express Buses, Blue Trunk Buses, Green Feeder Buses, and Yellow Tourist Shuttle Buses. Red Express Buses (such as Route 101 and Route 102) link Jeju International Airport with Seogwipo in rapid fashion, costing between 2,000 and 3,000 KRW. Yellow Tourist Loop Buses (Route 810 for the eastern region and Route 820 for the western region) circle key theme parks and natural landmarks with onboard tourist commentary guides. Payment is accepted via T-money transportation cards, with free transfers allowed twice within 40 minutes.

For walkers, the Jeju Olle Trail offers 27 routes totaling 437 km encircling the entire island. Trail signs feature the Ganse pony figure and orange-blue ribbons. For emergency medical assistance or travel questions, visitors can dial 1330 (Korea Travel Hotline, 24/7) or 064-740-6000 (Jeju Tourist Information Center).